

Adéla Isn’t Here to Apologize
By Alejandro Hernandez

On the cover of *The Provocateur*, ADÉLA is pictured urinating on a concrete wall, bearing just a thong, high block heels, and a leather jacket. Borrowing from the posture of men who do this without consequence, she stages an act of public indecency to question who's allowed to take up space.

Adéla Jergová, who moved from Slovakia to London to Los Angeles, was a seventeen-year-old contestant on *The Debut: Dream Academy,* a global talent program produced by HYBE (the industry giant behind BTS) in partnership with Geffen Records. The experiment aimed to leverage K-pop’s rigorous training model to create a first-of-its-kind ‘global girl group.’

Twenty trainees, chosen from over 120,000 global applicants, were filmed as they trained, performed, and adjusted to life under constant surveillance, only later discovering they were cast in an elimination competition. For a ballet prodigy raised on attendance and precision, the promise of mentorship and cultural immersion seemed like a dream.

After two years of training, she was eliminated after the show’s first public mission. When the docuseries, *Pop Star Academy: KATSEYE*, premiered a year later, editing framed her discipline as resentment and she was swiftly cast as the show's “mean girl.” Backlash was immediate, but with it came traction.

Outlets gave her space to share her side, early singles drew co-signs, and a fan base coalesced. “Let’s not make women look like they can’t have issues and resolve them maturely,” she told *Out*, a sentiment that would come to define her debut.

Later reflecting in *Teen Vogue*, she said the year after “f*cking sucked,” that the program “took [her] essence,” and left no room for authenticity. Rather than withdrawing, she released two singles independently, and then signed with Capitol Records. *The Provocateur* arrives as her rebuttal, delivered in her own language.



“I WANT TO ENCOURAGE SELF-EXPRESSION, TO THE FULLEST, WITH A LACK OF CARE FOR BEING PERCEIVED.”

The EP opens with “Superscar,” an energetic pop tune with occasional chain rattles, infectious harmonies, a slightly-anxious sensibility, and an impressive vocal showcase that reflects her relentless training. The track tackles the abuse of young women in the industry and feels indicative of the arrival of an artist with a complete understanding of the system she’s critiquing. She sings, *“Lucky, lucky you. You found your monetary fantasy,”* before surrendering to the hook,*“pull my strings and make me sing.”*

She then drops the listener into a labyrinth of eroticism and desperation, “SexOnTheBeat.” Between the deafening vocal moans, distorting bass, and subversive lyrics, the track walks the thin line between confrontation and conformity to wrestle with the pressure on female artists to become hypersexualized in order to achieve success. She metaphorizes performance as captivity, *“Give me rage, I give (sex on the beat) / Give me stage… / Give me cage..,”* and uses compliance to expose how easily submission can be mistaken for empowerment and control for exploitation. *“Do my dirty dance tonight / Serve it on a silver platter, baby / Make you think the choice is mine / Begging you to fetishize”* drive it even further, implicating the listener in the process. Each breath lends itself to a self-aware tension before suddenly cutting itself off, leaving the listener complicit, unsettled, and wanting more.

"LET'S NOT MAKE WOMEN LOOK LIKE THEY CAN'T HAVE ISSUES AND RESOLVE THEM MATURELY"

- ADÉLA JERGOVA



The next track, “MachineGirl,” uses cyber-femme electropop to dismantle the labels imposed on her. Co-produced by Grimes, the metallic autotune and synthetic distortion resemble how Adéla's image was cut, spliced, and repackaged for mass consumption. Repeating *“Mean girl, mean girl / What’s that even mean girl,”* she exposes how misogynistic narratives flatten ambition. She breaks through the distortion with, *“Wow! why don’t we ask the crowd,”* to call out the audience's compliance in rewarding drama while condemning women who embody it, intentionally or not.

“Homewrecked” trades the club textures for a cinematic EuroPop instrumental that disguises the generational betrayal underneath. The track finds Adéla exploring her sense of love and trust by confronting the harm caused by her father's infidelity. She opens, "*Dare, dare you to tell me,*" daring accountability from someone she knows won’t give it.*“Don’t shoot your baby,”* she threatens, while also recalling past harm and foreseeing its repetition. She thrashes the derogatory term, *“Dirty, little wh*re,”* to indict the misogyny fueling these cycles of blame. Beneath her anger, vengeance turns

introspective, so that by the end of the chorus, *“Look who’s homewrecked now-ow-ow,”* catharsis swaps retaliation, and the cycle of cruelty is broken by creating art from her pain.

A deep breath amidst the EP’s tension, “Go” channels release into forward motion. Against driving industrial-pop textures, she celebrates her ambition without the weight of scrutiny. It zooms out from the chaos of earlier tracks to provide a snapshot of an ambitious, young pop artist with little regard for approval.*“I just wanna go, baby I’m a dreamer,”* she sings with unguarded freedom, her upper and lower vocal registers shining in equal measure.

“DeathByDevotion” starts steady before exploding into an all-consuming anarchy. The punk pop-rock track, complete with irreverent electric guitar riffs and adlibs that edge on shrieks of pain, blurs punishment and dedication into something indistinguishable. "*Stuck in perpetual motion*" / "*Don't stop, my ego's showin' symptoms of death by devotion,*" she confesses, testing the limits of endurance. In two minutes, she distills her experience with ballet into an exposé of obsession and burnout that condemns femininity's cultural ties to perfection and indirect forms of self-destruction.

The EP is punctuated with a bold conclusion, “FinallyApologizing.” Despite the title, Adéla delivers a polite rebuttal to the criticism that's followed her since *Dream Academy. “Sorry that my friends are all still friends with me / And that I’m not as bad as you want me to be,”* she sings, mocking the public appetite for her downfall. "*You won't get what you want from me! Oh! Yeah,*" she chants, her voice layered over a buzzsaw synth, in a cadence that's redolent of a playground chant, a return to childhood that marks the beginning of something bigger.

The Provocateur signifies the advent of an unapologetic artist with something to say. Across its seven tracks, Adéla exposes exploitation while asserting the humanity it erases.

Every artistic choice feels intentional, down to the organization of the tracklist. Rarely does a debut feel this ferocious, self-aware, or alive.

The girls, gays, and theys are seated!

“I DON’T THINK I SHOULD BE A FOLLOWER BECAUSE OF WHERE I COME FROM. I THINK I SHOULD HAVE CREATIVE FREEDOM AND NOT GIVE A F*CK.”



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